AI FOR MANAGERS · STUDY GUIDE

Reinforce — Building and Sustaining Adoption

How do I keep the team's agreed way of working visible and active over time?

MODULE 5 · LESSON 2 | LEAD: CAPABILITY | Action lesson · 10–12 min

THE CORE IDEA

Repeated manager signals make desired ways of working more likely to continue.

Reinforcement reduces drift — it doesn't create adoption by itself.

1 Drift is the default

You've built the structure, and for the first time there's nothing new to set up. This is the moment most managers step back — and in the months that follow, teams quietly drift. Not because anyone gave up: old habits are easier, and busy weeks pull people back toward what they know. The counterweight is your attention — the team reads what you keep asking about, recognizing, and modeling as the real signal of what matters. Stop referring to the new way of working, and old habits come back. So does the silence.

Reinforce is the answer: not another document or meeting, but steady signals woven into interactions already happening — kickoffs, reviews, one-to-ones. It works in two directions: keeping what you've built working, and keeping the team ready for what's coming. Not a phase of the rollout — a standing part of the job.

2 Four levers, four kinds of signal

Reinforce runs on four levers: what you point the team at, what you praise, what you ask about, and what you do yourself.

Vision — say what AI is for

Keep the team's agreed statement alive by saying it in real work moments: *"We use AI to spend less time on first drafts and more time on client thinking."* Add the longer horizon — where AI's role is heading in six to twelve months — pitched at the team's output (products, clients, process), not individual tasks.

Recognition — name the good calls

Praise the *how*, not just the result: someone double-checking an AI answer, or a smart call about when not to trust it. "Good work" tells people nothing — naming the behavior shows everyone what good looks like. Say it in front of the team when it fits; check they're comfortable first.

Asking — ask how the work gets done

What you ask about tells the team what you care about. Swap *"how did it go?"* for *"how did you approach this?"* — then: what did you use AI for, where was the judgment call, where did you check the output, what would you do differently? No new meeting needed.

Modeling — go first yourself

People watch what you do more than what you say. If you want the team to use AI — and to be open about where it's hard — they have to see you doing both.

3 Modeling has two beats

At the start, show your own rough edges: a real attempt that took four tries, and what you learned. If you rarely use AI, don't fake it – pick one real task, try it, and report honestly. The point is to show that struggling is normal, you included; when you say it first, the team learns they're allowed to say it too.

Over time, shift from "I got it wrong" to "here's when I decided *not* to trust it, and why." If you only model success, the team learns struggling isn't allowed. Modeling judgment – when to use AI, when not to, what to double-check – is the real skill.

A QUICK SELF-SCAN OF THE FOUR LEVERS

1. **Vision** – do I say out loud what AI is for, and where we're heading with it, in real work moments?
2. **Recognition** – when someone makes a smart call with AI, do I name it?
3. **Asking** – do I ask how people worked, or only whether it got done?
4. **Modeling** – have I recently shown the team my own AI use, and how it actually went?

Then: pick the lever you're weakest on and use it once this week, in one real conversation or meeting. That scan is the first entry in your **Lead AI Adoption Plan** – a running record of how you lead adoption, built one lesson at a time.

WHAT TO DO DIFFERENTLY AFTER THIS LESSON

- Don't step back once the structure is built – drift is the default, and your attention is the counterweight.
- Recognize the specific behavior you want more of: verification, judgment, honest experiments.
- Ask *"how did you approach this?"* and let the answers show you how work actually gets made.
- Go first on difficulty, then graduate to modeling judgment.

Module 5 · Lead: Capability – the module that turns the standard into durable capability. **Next: Lesson 5.3 – Develop – Moving Each Person Forward** – a different role: moving each person forward, one at a time.